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Mobile Newsmaking

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Licentiate Thesis

Abstract

The research reported in this thesis concerns the design of new and innovative IT support for mobile news journalism. News journalists often have to report events on topics that they do not know very well and with little time for preparation. News reporting is often conducted in the field, away from the stationary IT support.

The scope of this research is limited to the early phase of newsmaking when journalists transform everyday occurrences and happenings into newsworthy stories, discuss news events and formulate news tasks, do background research and frame news stories. The research question addressed is: *How to provide reporters with contextual information relevant for news tasks in mobile situations?* Contextual information reminds the reporter of the context for the task at hand. Helps the reporter to ask relevant and interesting questions and to properly frame the news story.

The thesis contains field studies, design implications and applications of mobile technologies. The following theoretical and practical results are described: 1) NewsSpace, a design model describing new ways of using IT in news journalism, 2) NewsMate, a prototype of an IT service for mobile reporters, 3) FieldWise, a generalised architecture for mobile knowledge management, 4) A description of the newsmaking process focusing on the early phase of articulation and contextualisation of news tasks, and 5) A news task structure, called Localising News, and proposals of how the utilisation of task structures could improve the IT support for mobile news journalism.

Keywords

Informatics, Mobile CSCW, Journalism, Ethnography, Empirically informed systems design, Handheld devices

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Preface

The thesis is a collection of four papers and an introduction. This forms the result of a collaboration effort between academia and industry that started in 1997 when the Viktoria institute was established and a Ph.D. programme for people in industry was launched. The work reported in the thesis has been done as part of the Mobile Informatics programme. Mobile Informatics is an applied research area exploring and realising new and innovative IT services for the "nomadic networker" of the future.

The overall task for the research is the *design of new and innovative IT services supporting mobile news journalism*. The specific research question is: *How to provide reporters with contextual information for news tasks in mobile situations?*

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During the last four years combining work and research, I have been working in different organisations. Most of the time I have been employed at Astrakan Strategic Development. I have been encouraged by two of the founders of Astrakan: Clas-Göran Lövetoft and Jonas Leffler. Clas-Göran has been my mentor as being an explorer himself. Jonas has been my supporter as also being a part time researcher.

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Kerstin Forsberg, Göteborg, November 2001.

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Note: a digital version of the thesis is available at http://www.viktoria.se/~kerstinf/thesis/ This web page also includes errata and links to additional material.